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How to tell if your *saffron is real*

Four checks you can do at home, and what they cannot tell you

A SHORT GUIDE

What gets sold as saffron

Saffron is the most expensive spice in the world by weight, which makes it worth faking. Most fraud is not sophisticated. It is cheap plant material, dyed red, cut in with the real thing or sold on its own.

THE USUAL SUBSTITUTES

Dyed corn silk

The most common physical substitute. Flat, smooth and the same width along its whole length. Real saffron is not.

Safflower petals

Sometimes sold as false saffron. Uniform orange, flat, and close to tasteless.

Marigold and calendula

Petals rather than stigmas. Wrong shape once you know what to look for.

Dyed fibers

Coconut fiber, dyed threads, even paper. Rough or unnaturally even in texture.

Turmeric and paprika

Used in powdered saffron, where nothing can be inspected by eye.

> *Buy threads, never powder. Once saffron is ground, none of the checks in this guide work, and powder is where most adulteration happens.*

WHY THE PRICE TELLS YOU SOMETHING

A saffron crocus produces three red stigmas. They are picked by hand, on the morning the flower opens, and it takes roughly one hundred and fifty flowers to make a single gram.

That labor sets a floor. Real saffron cannot be produced cheaply, so saffron offered far below the going rate is either not saffron, not the grade claimed, or old stock that has lost its strength. Treat a surprisingly low price as a question rather than a bargain.

Four checks before you cook

01

Look at the end of the thread

A real stigma flares at one end into a trumpet or frayed shape, and tapers towards the other. It varies in width along its length. Corn silk and dyed fibers are even all the way down, with smooth edges and no flare.

02

Put five threads in warm water

This is the most useful check. Use cool or warm water, never boiling, and wait. Real saffron releases color slowly over ten to fifteen minutes and the water turns golden yellow. The threads themselves stay red. Dyed material bleeds within seconds, usually red or orange rather than gold, and the threads go pale.

03

Smell it

Real saffron smells of hay and honey, with a faint floral edge underneath. If it smells of nothing, or smells sweet in a confected way, something is wrong.

04

Taste one thread, last

Only do this if the water test looked right. Dyed material can carry industrial colorants you do not want to swallow. Real saffron tastes bitter. It is never sweet. Safflower is close to tasteless, and anything sweet has usually been coated to add weight.

> **Do it side by side**
>
> One sample on its own is hard to judge. Two glasses next to each other, same number of threads, same water, same time, and the difference is obvious within a minute. It is the most revealing thing you can do without a laboratory.

What these checks cannot tell you

The four checks catch crude fraud. They will not tell you how strong your saffron is, and strength is what you actually pay for.

Two tins can both be real saffron and perform completely differently in a pot. Age, drying method and how much of the pale style was left attached all change the result. Only a laboratory reading tells you that.

Laboratory testing has limits too. The standard ISO 3632 method measures strength, not authenticity, and research has found it can miss safflower, marigold or turmeric mixed in at under twenty percent.

WHAT A LABEL SHOULD TELL YOU

- The grade, as an ISO 3632 category rather than a marketing word
- The crocin reading, which is color strength
- A lot number, so the tin ties back to a specific test
- Where it was grown, by region rather than by continent
- A best before date

Words like premium, pure, Grade A+ and finest mean nothing. None of them is a defined standard. If a seller cannot give you a number, they are asking you to take their word for it.

SOURCES

ISO 3632-1 and ISO 3632-2, International Organization for Standardization, on saffron specification and test methods.
On the limits of ISO 3632 in detecting safflower, marigold and turmeric below twenty percent: published research in the Journal of Pharmaceutical and Biomedical Analysis and related peer-reviewed work on saffron authentication.
On corn silk and other look-alikes: Frontiers in Plant Science, microscopic identification of fake saffron, 2022.

Every tin tells you exactly what it holds.

Azaad publishes the laboratory readings for every lot we sell.
Enter the lot code from any tin and see the numbers for that batch.

azaadsaffron.com/verify.html